THE GALLEY WAS INVENTED in the eastern Mediterranean in the early 3rd millennium BCE. Although galleys had a sail or sails, they were distinguished by the fact that they could be propelled by oars alone if required. Oars were used either when the wind was absent or contrary, or when faster propulsion was required or tighter maneuver—as in battle. These extraordinary war machines, propelled by their great gangs of oarsmen, held their place, with variations of design and tactics, as the prime warships of Europe for around 3,000 years. From the 15th century onward galleys were gradually supplanted by ocean-going sailing ships, capable of year-round operation in all weathers and providing a superior platform for heavy cannon.



Minoan galley
A fresco found on the Greek island of Akrotiri, dating from c.1700 BCE, shows a procession of galleys from one coastal port to another. In this detail, the man standing at the back of the boat holds a steering oar, a feature of all Egyptian, Greek, and Roman ships.

EARLY GALLEY WARFARE

The first recorded use of a warship was an Egyptian sortie into Lebanon and Palestine around 2450 BCE, when troops were landed by sea, presumably ferried from the Nile delta. By the reign of the great pharaoh Thutmose III a thousand years later, seaborne movement of troops was standard Egyptian practice. By this time another warlike use of galleys was emerging. In Egyptian sources around 1500—1300 BCE there is a record of sea raiders seizing merchant ships, attacking coastal settlements, and blockading ports. There are reckoned by this time to have been galleys that carried marines—including archers and javelin-throwers—and others in which the rowers doubled as fighting men, as they would later in the era of the Vikings.

Actual battles at sea emerge in shadowy form in the historical record around the 12th century BCE. At first there was no evidence of naval maneuvers—these were simply fights between soldiers on water. But the sea-going peoples of the eastern Mediterranean, especially the Phoenicians and the Greeks, developed skills as sailors that could be applied to warfare, using the first specialist warships, the penteconter and the trireme.

PERSIA AND THE GREEEKS

Some of the basics of naval warfare became evident very early on. To become a naval power a state needed a population with seafaring skills and the resources to finance a fleet—it has always been very expensive to build and man a body of ships. The Persian Empire was the first state to develop a fleet as an element in large-scale power-projection, buying the services of Phoenician and Greek sailors to provide the necessary expertise. Faced with a Persian invasion in the 5th century BCE,



Early Greek battle at sea
Many images of naval warfare appear on Greek ceramics. On this *krater* (a vessel used for mixing wine and water) from the 7th century BCE the ship on the left is a penteconter with a ram at the prow.





